



Family investigator-preparation record

Start with safety - this workbook can wait

Nothing written here is sent to MMIPS. Keep the completed workbook private and do not post it online. Call 911 for immediate danger. Report the person missing as soon as you are concerned; you do not need to finish this first, and you may leave anything blank.

1. First steps

- ☐ Call 911 if there is immediate danger or urgent risk.
- ☐ Report the person missing as soon as you are concerned. Do not wait to complete this workbook.
- ☐ Ask for the case or file number and the lead investigator or family liaison.
- ☐ Tell the investigator about urgent health, medication, disability, weather, terrain, violence, or exploitation risks.
- ☐ Ask what information and which photograph are safe to release publicly.

Person and primary case contact

Full legal name

Birth date and current age

Person making this record and relationship

Date and time first reported

Case or file number

Direct official phone and email

Chosen name, nickname, aliases, and pronouns

Tribal Nation, Alaska Native, Native Hawaiian, or community affiliation (optional)

Private callback number and email

Tribal, local, state, territorial, or federal agency receiving the report

Lead investigator or family liaison

Agreed date and time for the next update



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2. Complete physical description

Use the person's current appearance. If you do not know, leave it blank. Investigators can help fill gaps.

Height

Hair colour, length, and style

Facial hair

Assigned sex at birth, if requested for identification

Weight

Eye colour

Glasses or contacts

Gender identity or expression

Build

Skin tone / complexion

Languages / interpreter needs

Self-described race, ethnicity, or appearance (optional)

Tattoos - design, words, colour, body location, and whether new or changed

Scars, birthmarks, skin marks, or surgical marks - description and location

Mobility aid, prosthetic, disability, dominant hand, posture, gait, or recognizable movement

Piercings, jewellery, dental work, braces, or other identifying features

Other identifying details investigators may need



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Last seen, clothing, transportation

3. Last seen and last contact

Date and time last seen in person

Last person known to see or contact them

Exact last-seen or last-contact location for investigators

Keep this private. Include address, unit, landmark, route, or coordinates only when useful to investigators.

Broad area the investigating agency says may be safe to share publicly

Use a community or region, not a private address.

Plans, destination, who they expected to meet, and expected return time

Top, bottom, dress, uniform, or other clothing

Shoes or boots - type, brand, colour, and size if known

Vehicle or transportation - year, make, model, colour, licence plate, jurisdiction, damage, stickers, bicycle, transit, taxi, rideshare, or walking route

Date and time of last phone, text, email, or online contact

That person's contact information

What made you concerned; anything unusual or out of character

Coat, sweater, hat, head covering, gloves, or weather gear

Jewellery, watch, bag, wallet, phone, mobility aid, or items carried



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Timeline, people, places, routines

4. Timeline and confirmed information

Mark estimates clearly and give investigators the source for each detail.

1. Date and time

Place, contact, sighting, or event

Who knows this and contact information

2. Date and time

Place, contact, sighting, or event

Who knows this and contact information

3. Date and time

Place, contact, sighting, or event

Who knows this and contact information

4. Date and time

Place, contact, sighting, or event

Who knows this and contact information

5. Date and time

Place, contact, sighting, or event

Who knows this and contact information

Work, school, attendance, contacts, and travel routine

Usual routes, appointments, cultural or spiritual places, and regular locations

Family, friends, partners, co-workers, neighbours, Elders, and service-provider contacts

Phone numbers, carriers, devices, email addresses, usernames, games, and social handles - no passwords or PINs



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Private safety and risk information

5. Private safety and risk information

Personal questions are used to assess risk, not to judge

Share these details privately with the investigating agency. Do not put them in public posts. You can say that you do not know and provide updates later.

- ☐ Urgent medical, medication, mental-health, disability, cognitive, or mobility needs
- ☐ Recent trauma, unusual behaviour, distress, or reason this is out of character
- ☐ Relationship violence, stalking, coercion, trafficking, exploitation, or another threat
- ☐ Housing instability, remote terrain, severe weather, inadequate clothing, or transportation risk
- ☐ Substance-use information that may help assess immediate safety or likely locations
- ☐ Access to weapons or another immediate danger
- ☐ Prior disappearances and where the person was previously located
- ☐ Other private information that may help investigators assess risk and locate the person

Health, disability, medication, treatment, or urgent-care details

Other private risk information, recent events, relationships, or likely locations investigators should know

Items missing or left behind - phone, wallet, keys, identification, medication, clothing, cash, passport, vehicle, treasured item, or other belongings



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6. Gather photographs - do not attach them here

Gather copies for investigators and keep originals safe

This workbook does not ask for photographs and does not upload anything. Ask the investigator which image may be released publicly. A public image should respect how the person would want to be represented.

- ☐ Recent clear face photo showing current hairstyle and appearance
- ☐ Recent full-body photo
- ☐ Side or profile photo, if available
- ☐ Photos showing tattoos, scars, birthmarks, piercings, or other identifying features
- ☐ Photo of usual glasses, jewellery, mobility aid, or another recognizable item
- ☐ Photo of vehicle, bicycle, or other regular transportation
- ☐ Original or highest-resolution files, not screenshots when originals exist
- ☐ A family-approved image that respects how the person would want to be represented

Where photo files or originals are safely kept; filenames supplied to investigators

Who received each photo, date and method supplied, and whether it was approved for public release

Protect dignity and privacy

Do not post the completed workbook. Do not publish private addresses, shelters, witnesses, medical details, exact sensitive locations, accusations, graphic information, or an image the family has not approved.



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Records and identification sources

7. Gather records and possible identification sources

- ☐ Government identification; correct legal name, birth date, and aliases
- ☐ Dentist / orthodontist contact; ask about dental records and X-rays
- ☐ Doctor, clinic, pharmacy, urgent medical needs, and current medications
- ☐ Possible fingerprint source: employment, military, immigration, licensing, or prior records
- ☐ Phone numbers, device type, carrier, email addresses, and social-media usernames
- ☐ Vehicle registration, plate, make, model, year, colour, damage, and stickers
- ☐ Work, school, travel, transportation, and regular-location information
- ☐ Existing reports, official reference numbers, approved posters, and public tip contacts

Dentist / orthodontist name, office, phone, and dates treated**Doctor, clinic, hospital, pharmacy, and phone****Where fingerprints may exist****Who requested each record, date requested, and status****Other identification source, device, document, or provider investigators should know about**

Preserve before handling

Ask the investigator before cleaning or disturbing the person's room, vehicle, clothing, toothbrush, hairbrush, razor, devices, or other belongings. Do not collect DNA yourself. Ask before accessing accounts or organizing a search that could create safety or evidence concerns.



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8. Agencies and services

Not every service fits every case. Start with emergency help and the agency taking the report. Ask the lead investigator which additional contacts are appropriate so reports stay coordinated.

STATUS		AGENCY OR SERVICE
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	911, when there is immediate danger
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	Local, Tribal, or territorial law-enforcement agency
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	Lead investigator or family liaison
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	BIA Missing and Murdered Unit, when the case or jurisdiction may apply
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	FBI or another federal agency, when directed or jurisdiction may apply
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	State or territory missing-person clearinghouse
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	NamUs after a police report is filed; ask about agency or family entry
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	NCMEC after law enforcement if the missing person is under 18
☐ Need to contact	☐ Contacted	Victim services, Tribal family support, coroner, or medical examiner, when applicable

Country-specific contact note

BIA MMU: 1-833-560-2065 / OJS_MMU@bia.gov. NCMEC under 18, after law enforcement: 1-800-THE-LOST.

Additional agency, advocate, victim service, Elder, interpreter, cultural support, coroner, medical examiner, or other contact

Which agency leads, which agencies have the report, and how updates will be shared



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9. Detailed agency call log - contacts 1 to 4

Record each call, visit, email, transfer, and promised follow-up. Write down names and times while the conversation is fresh.

1. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

2. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

3. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

4. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action



9. Detailed agency call log - contacts 5 to 8

Record each call, visit, email, transfer, and promised follow-up. Write down names and times while the conversation is fresh.

5. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

6. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

7. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action

8. Agency or service

Phone or email used

Person spoken with

Date and time

File or reference number

What they said, promised follow-up, and next action



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Questions, follow-up, public information

10. Questions to ask the investigator

- ☐ Was the person entered into NCIC?
- ☐ Which agency and investigator lead the case?
- ☐ What urgent risks and search actions are documented?
- ☐ Who is the family liaison and when is the next update?
- ☐ Should the case be entered in NamUs?
- ☐ Should BIA MMU, FBI, NCMEC, or another agency be involved?
- ☐ Are dental records, fingerprints, DNA, medical records, or device records needed?
- ☐ What information and photo may be released publicly?

Other questions and the answers received

Next steps - who is responsible and when to follow up

Information approved for public use

Exact facts and photo filenames approved by the family and investigating agency

Official public tip phone, email, website, and case number

Information that must stay private or must not be published

Trusted support, victim service, Elder, cultural support, interpreter, rest plan, or help with calls

Official guidance used to shape this workbook (checked August 15, 2026)

Official references: bia.gov/service/mmu; namus.nij.ojp.gov/services and [/frequently-asked-questions](https://namus.nij.ojp.gov/frequently-asked-questions)
For a missing child: ncmec.org/gethelpnow/isyourchildmissing